

reservations had not secured their privileged seats. Vociferous supplications and threats were directed toward the omnipotent conductors, who rationed out the seats to the pleading travelers, presumably not without a great deal of money changing hands.

This might remain a quaint memory but for the fact that with a few exceptions, such as the sophisticated and excellent Delhi subway system, the situation remains unchanged today. Indian railway carriages are still routinely crowded with two or three times as many passengers as they are meant to carry, making every arrival and departure a stampede of hundreds of people; a massive, surging sea of humanity jostling to find their bags in the caboose, and then solicited by dozens of *coolies* for the job of carrying those bags to waiting cars. More than an inconvenience for passengers, overcrowding often permits passengers without tickets to sneak aboard, leading to financial losses for Indian Railways. Moreover, railway accidents cause about three hundred deaths a year, most caused by people being run over by trains.

In Bombay Central Station, where we disembarked during my childhood summer sojourns, I remember often arriving to a city submerged in knee-deep water—a result of the summer monsoons and substandard city drainage. We children sailed paper boats on the flooded roads; motorists, who had abandoned their cars by the roadside until the water receded, went to great trouble to protect the matches they needed to dry out their carburetors once it became possible to restart their cars. This extreme flooding, a direct result of a mismanaged and thoroughly faulty government infrastructure, happened in Bombay as recently as 2005.

Government-owned utilities need not succumb to the deplorable inefficiency of Indian Railways and the Bombay sewer system. China's Maglev train is a striking case in point. *Sleek, efficient, immaculate, and orderly* were adjectives that immediately came to mind during my first high-speed ride from Shanghai airport to Pudong. A space-age construction based on German technology, the rail was built by the Chinese government in just three years, with exactly one accident (no injuries) in two and a half years of operation. *Maglev* is short for "magnetic levitation"—itself a metaphor for China's prowess—whereby a magnet on the bottom of the train runs over a piece of metal "track", causing electric currents to flow through the metal and produce enough force to push the magnet upward.

Maglev may be an exception, but even regular trains—that is, public services—work far better in China than in

India. A train ride I took from Nanjing to Shanghai revealed the differences. The Nanjing Station resembles a modern airport, not the New Delhi-like higgledy-piggledy of human activity. The architecture of the Chinese station is not unusual—rows of platforms into which trains pulled in with overarching pedestrian bridges—but Nanjing's modern escalators are in sharp contrast to the dilapidated stairs, often crowded with beggars, that one is forced to climb in New Delhi. The government employees of the train station look worn down in New Delhi; in Nanjing, they were smartly dressed, some in maroon uniforms and some in white. Finding a seat is not a chore in Nanjing, one seat is not assigned to many people, and, although crowded, the trains

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MADDING CROWD: At New Delhi railway station, every departure is a stampede move smoothly toward on-time arrivals, all unlike New Delhi. The only time when there are hundreds of people milling around the station is during Chinese New Year when all of China is on the move. In short, public services work in China.

Whereas order, harmony, and hierarchy have been the constant goals of the Chinese state, India has a proud tradition of pluralism, dissent, and debate. Anyone seeking to engage in dialogue with these countries must understand the fundamentally different

ideologies and political antecedents of their current practices. They are deep seated and long lived.

If the CCP wants to continue to run China, it must work toward meeting the rising aspirations of an increasingly greater proportion of the people, moving beyond providing basic material goods and services. Its success has sown the seeds of its future challenges.